

IN AND AROUND THE BOOK OF DANIEL

CHAPTER I

INTRODUCTION

WITH the spread of learning and the issue from time to time of fresh commentaries on the Book of Daniel, it is now a matter of common knowledge that two very different views are held respecting that Book, which, for the sake of a name, may be styled respectively the orthodox and the critical—not that all critics are on the same side, but simply that the majority of modern critics incline to the latter view. They may also be styled the Roman and the Grecian, according to the scheme of interpretation adopted with regard to the Four Kingdoms in the vision of Daniel, chaps. ii. and vii. In a book written in defence of the orthodox position it may be well to devote the first chapter to explaining the main difficulty which confronts the upholders of that position, and to showing how that difficulty may be met without having recourse to the solution proposed by the critics—a solution which does great violence to the Book of Daniel as a whole, and creates more difficulties than it removes.

According to the orthodox view, the Book of Daniel is a narrative of some surprising events that happened in the life of a saintly Jewish captive, holding a very high position at the courts of Babylon and of Persia, a fragmentary biography of one who was a special favourite of heaven, including visions such as have been granted to no other man, except possibly the beloved apostle—visions reaching to the end of time. Thus viewed, this Book occupies a unique position in the Old Testament, and as such it was treated by the Founder of Christianity, for there is no other Book of the Old Testament to which Christ pays greater honour than to this Book of Daniel. The estimate, however, of this Book formed by the critics is something far different. To them it appears as one of the Pseudepigrapha, or Jewish religious

books, written under a false, or rather an assumed name, which appeared in the second and first centuries B.C., such as the Book of Enoch and the Testaments of the Twelve Patriarchs. They would probably confess it to be the most remarkable of those books, the noblest and the loftiest in its teaching, the grandest in its scope no less than in its descriptions, a literary work of superlative merit; but at the same time a merely human composition. To put the matter in another light, the critics look upon the Book of Daniel as a religious novel, resting upon a shadowy background of history, written about 164 B.C. in the troublous days of the Maccabees, and written with this noble intention, viz. to encourage the faithful in a time of persecution and to support them under very severe trials. Accordingly they see much in this Book that meets with their approval, and are fully awake to its literary beauties. But, all the same, it is in their eyes a mere work of the imagination, cleverly put together, but containing not a few historical inaccuracies, owing to its having been written some three or four hundred years after the times which it describes. To them, therefore, its great facts are pure fancies; its mighty miracles, mere feats of the imagination; its so-called prophecies, past history clothed with the garb of prophecy—a favourite practice in the apocalypses of the Pseudepigrapha. If this view of the matter be the correct one, the puzzle is, How did this Book of Daniel come to be included in the sacred Canon of the Old Testament? and how came it to be treated by our Lord Jesus Christ with such special honour?

The question is altogether such an important one that we may well ask on what ground the critical view is based. And here it is not sufficient to answer that the critics as a body believe neither in miracle nor in prophecy. This doubtless is the case with some, but it is not the whole truth of the matter. To understand their position aright we must turn to the long and striking prophecy of Daniel, chap. xi., which foretells the sufferings of the Jewish people under the Greek empire of Syria, more particularly in the days of Antiochus the Great and his son Antiochus Epiphanes. This chapter is the great crux of the Book of Daniel, and on the remarkable features presented by it the critics base an argument, which at first sight seems unanswerable, to show that the Book was written, as stated above, in or about the year 164 B.C. This argument is admirably set forth by the late Prof. Driver in his Commentary on Daniel. Speaking of chap. xi. Dr. Driver says, "The minuteness of the predictions, embracing even special events in the distant future, is out of harmony with the analogy of prophecy." This is certainly true, for we do not

find such detailed prophecies in Isaiah, Jeremiah, or Zechariah ; and yet such an argument, taken alone, is not of itself fatal to the authenticity of a Book which in some respects is unique. For surely it may well be granted that the Almighty Ruler of the world knows the end from the beginning, and can, if He sees fit, unfold with minuteness the events even of a far-distant future. The real difficulty is explained by Dr. Driver in the following words : “ While down to the period of Antiochus’ persecution the *actual* facts are described with surprising distinctness, after this point *the distinctness ceases* : the closing events of Antiochus’ own life are, to all appearance, not described as they actually occurred.”¹ We venture to think that any honest critic who has studied the matter will be ready to endorse this statement. Thus, in chap. xi. 21–39 we find described many events in Antiochus’ remarkable career, *e.g.* his coming into the kingdom by stealth and gaining power by flattery, *v.* 21 ; his lavish prodigality, *v.* 24 ; his two expeditions against Egypt (the second, owing to the interposition of the Romans, terminating so differently from the first), *vv.* 25–30 ; his persecution of the Jews when returning from his first Egyptian expedition, *v.* 28 ; his attempt to put down and stamp out the temple worship when returning crest-fallen from his second expedition, *v.* 31 ; the early triumphs of the Maccabees, *v.* 34 ; the assumption by Antiochus of divine honours during the later years of his reign, when he appears on coins as “ Antiochus, the God Manifest,” *v.* 36 ; and, finally, the special honours paid by him to Jupiter Capitolinus, “ the god of fortresses,” *vv.* 38, 39. But when we pass over the evident pause at the close of this 39th verse, this distinctness ceases, and we make what Prof. Charles styles “ a transition from history to prophecy ”² : prophecy which fits in very badly if we restrict and apply it to the closing events of Antiochus’ career. Thus, nothing is known from secular history of any further invasion of Egypt such as is described in *vv.* 40–42 ; whilst Antiochus himself, so far from “ having power over the treasures of gold and of silver and over all the precious things of Egypt,” *v.* 43, was in sore financial straits towards the close of his life, and died, not in the Holy Land, as *v.* 45 seems to imply, but in Elymais, after a fruitless attempt to rob a temple of its treasures. If, then, we take these closing verses, 40–45, to apply to Antiochus Epiphanes, they appear before us as a prophecy that was never fulfilled ; in fact as nothing more than a vain surmise. From the above phenomena the critics have drawn the very evident conclusion

¹ *Cambridge Bible*, Daniel, Introduction, p. lxvi.

² *Century Bible*, Daniel, p. 136.